

Brand & UI Standards - Builder Playbook

Project Template v1.0 | 8 Apr 2026 | Adrian K. L. Ang

How to use this template: The REFERENCE column is pre-filled from ai-jobskill-analyser v2 (takearoundabout.com). The NEW PROJECT column is blank - fill it in at the start of each new project before writing any code. Rows marked [RULE] apply to every project and should not be changed without a documented reason.

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1. Design Principles

These rules govern every visual and copy decision in a project. They are non-negotiable defaults. Any exception requires a documented reason.

#	Principle	What it means in practice
P1	Tool shows, does not tell	The interface presents information and respects the user's judgement. It does not prescribe, instruct, or assume a decision has been made. No language that tells the user what they must do.
	Progressive	Show the minimum first. Reveal on demand. Every surface has one

P2	disclosure	job. No two panels repeat the same content in different words.
P3	Colour encodes meaning, never decoration	Every colour token is assigned a semantic role. Adding a colour because it looks nice is not permitted. If a colour is used, it must carry meaning the user can learn.
P4	Mobile first at 375px	Every layout decision is made at 375px first. Wider screens are an enhancement. No feature is designed desktop-first and adapted down.
P5	Indicative framing	Results, outputs, and AI-generated content are always framed as starting points, not verdicts. Language: a starting point, indicative, may vary. Never: definitively, always, guaranteed.
P6	Earned credibility	No self-promotional language. No brochure copy. No claims that cannot be verified. Credibility comes from honest, precise language and visible sourcing.
P7	Restraint over volume	Fewer elements, more breathing room. If a line of copy can be removed without losing meaning, remove it. If a feature serves the builder's ego rather than the user's need, cut it.
P8	Think before build	No code is written until the approach has been assessed honestly. Honest assessment includes naming what could go wrong, what the cost is, and what the simpler alternative is.

2. Typography

2.1 Font Families

Rule: Use the system font stack as the default. Only introduce an external font if there is a specific, scoped reason. Document the scope and the CDN dependency. Never add a font globally for aesthetic reasons alone.

Role	Rule	Application	Reference project	New project
Primary / body font	System stack	<code>font-family: system-ui, sans-serif</code> . No CDN dependency. Applied to entire app.	system-ui / sans-serif	

Accent font	Scoped only	Loaded via Google Fonts or similar CDN. Scoped to one component via inline <code>fontFamily</code> style. Document which component and why.	DM Sans - PreviewSection card only	
Code / monospace	Browser default	<code>fontFamily: monospace</code> . No named font. Applied only to prompt pre blocks and code output areas.	monospace (Courier / Menlo)	

2.2 Typographic Scale - Mobile Base (< 768px)

Rule: Define all scale values at mobile base first. Responsive overrides are applied via CSS class at breakpoints (see Section 5). Inline `px` values do not respond to browser font size settings - this is a known limitation to accept consciously.

Role / CSS class	Size (px)	Weight	Line height	Reference project usage	New project usage
t-heading	17	800	1.3	Primary page-level heading. One per screen.	
t-body	14	500-700	varies	Skill names, occupation titles, main labels.	
t-label	13	600	1.5	Apply line, section labels in result tabs.	
t-sub	12	400-600	1.6-1.85	AI summary text, explanation body copy.	
t-meta	11	400	1.65	Prompt pre block. Monospace font.	
result-text-sm	12	400	varies	Skill names inside dense comparison rows.	
Section label (UPPER)	10-11	700	1.5	All-caps labels: AI Tool, Approach, Skills. <code>letterSpacing: 0.05-</code>	

				0.06em .	
Badge / micro	9-10	600-700	1	Readiness badges, technique badges, ESCO links.	
Muted hint / helper	10-11	400	1.5	Under-input hints, italic footnotes.	
Search / main input	15	400	normal	Primary search box. Largest interactive text.	
Tab pill	13	700	normal	Navigation tab labels.	
[RULE] Minimum body size	12px	-	-	Never set body copy below 12px on any screen size.	
[RULE] Minimum badge size	9px	-	-	9px is the floor. Below this text becomes illegible on retina screens.	

2.3 Responsive Font Scaling - CSS Class Overrides

Rule: Scale `t-*` classes upward at each breakpoint using `!important` overrides in the global style block. Inline `px` values do not scale - use `t-*` classes on any text that should respond to viewport width.

Class	< 768px	768px	1024px	1280px	1600px	2000px	2560px
<code>t-heading</code>	17	18	20	21	21	24	28
<code>t-body</code>	14	15	16	16	16	18	20
<code>t-label</code>	13	13	14	14	14	15	17
<code>t-sub</code>	12	13	14	14	14	16	17
<code>t-meta</code>	11	12	13	13	13	14	15
<code>html font-size</code>	14px	15px	16px	16px	16px	18px	20px

New project values - fill in:

Class	< 768px	768px	1024px	1280px	1600px	2000px	2560px	Notes
t- heading								
t-body								
t- label								
t-sub								
t-meta								
html font- size								

2.4 Font Weights

Weight	Reference project usage	New project usage
800 Extra Bold	Page headings. PreviewSection card heading. Comparison section titles.	
700 Bold	Card headings. Tab pills. All-caps labels. Badge text.	
600 Semi-Bold	Skill names in expanded rows. Apply line. Stage feed status.	
500 Medium	Skill name in closed row header. Occupation card titles.	
400 Regular	Body copy. Descriptions. Hint text. Muted labels.	

2.5 Letter Spacing

Value	Rule / context	Reference project	New project
0.05–0.06em	Uppercase section labels. Use with <code>fontWeight: 700</code> and <code>textTransform: uppercase</code> .	PROMPT label, Career paths, Skills to develop	
0.03–0.04em	Status labels and micro uppercase text that is not a full section header.	IntroCard audience label, LivePromptCard status	
–0.01em	Large bold headings only (<code>fontWeight: 800+</code>). Tightens letter pairs at display size.	PreviewSection Sample Result heading	
[RULE]	Never use negative tracking below –0.02em . Reduces legibility on mobile.	-	-

3. Colour System

Rule: Define all colours as named tokens before writing any code. Never use raw hex values inline unless the colour is unique to a single component and is documented as a spot colour in Section 3.4. Every colour token must have a semantic role.

3.1 Core Token Palette

Token	Semantic role - rule	Reference hex	New project hex
bg	Page background. Never pure white at page level. Slightly tinted.	#f5f7fa	
surface	Card and panel surface. Elevated containers. Always white.	#ffffff	
border	Default border. All cards, inputs, dividers. One value used consistently.	#dde3ec	
accent	Primary brand colour. Active states, primary buttons, nav accent. The one colour a user learns.	#1a56db	

accentSoft	Accent at 10% opacity equivalent. Info banners, selected row backgrounds.	#e8f0fe	
text	Primary text. Headings, strong labels. Near-black, not pure black.	#1a202c	
textSub	Secondary body text. Descriptions, notes. Legible but receded.	#4a5568	
muted	Tertiary / helper text. Placeholder copy, inactive labels.	#6b7a8d	
mutedLight	Quaternary. Collapse arrows, number badges, least important elements.	#9aa5b4	

3.2 Semantic Colour Pairs

Every status or state requires three values: text colour, background, and border. Define all pairs before writing component code.

Pair name	Semantic role	Ref text	Ref bg	Ref border	New project (text / bg / border)
success / human	Human-Led level. Completion. Shared skills.	#166534	#ecfdf5	#a7f3d0	
info / active	Info banners. Selected states. Active nav.	#1a56db	#e8f0fe	#c3d3f5	
warning / caution	Notices. May not apply. Skill count variance.	#b45309	#fffbeb	#fcd9a0	
error / destructive	Not found, invalid input. Confirm delete.	#dc2626	#fdecea	#f5c6c2	
special / persona	Industry Crossover persona. Prep needed badge.	#7c3aed	#f3e8ff	#ddd6fe	

reflection / AI output	AI-generated summaries. Humble, non-prescriptive.	#0e7490	#ecfeff	#a5f3fc	
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3.3 Automation / Category Level Colours

Use this pattern whenever a product categorises items into levels, tiers, or states with distinct visual weight. Four levels is the established maximum - more than four becomes unlearnable.

Level name	Semantic meaning	Ref text	Ref bg	Ref border	New project (text / bg / border)
Level 1 (highest risk)	Maximum change, highest automation. Red signals urgency.	#dc2626	#fef2f2	#fecaca	
Level 2	Significant change. Amber signals caution and transition.	#d97706	#fffbeb	#fcd9a0	
Level 3	Moderate change. Blue signals tool-assisted, controllable.	#2563eb	#eff6ff	#bdfdbf	
Level 4 (human / safe)	Least change, most human. Green signals safety, resilience.	#166534	#f0fdf4	#a7f3d0	
[RULE] Maximum four levels	More than four colour-coded categories become unlearnable. If you need more, use grouping within levels.	-	-	-	-

3.4 Spot Colours

Spot colours are acceptable only when a colour is unique to a single component and cannot

be expressed as a token. Document each one here. **Maximum five spot colours per project.**

Hex	Component	Why not a token	New project equivalent
#0369a1	Prompt block heading label, copy button text	Prompt blue is distinct from accent. Using accent would collapse the meaning of both.	
#f97316	LivePromptCard in-progress dot only	Orange communicates live activity, distinct from accent or warning. One element only.	
#86198f	What to do Next heading for Full Automation skills	Purple signals transformative action for the highest-risk skills. Not used elsewhere.	

4. Spacing and Shape

4.1 Border Radius Scale

Rule: Use the smallest border radius that makes the element feel intentional, not decorative. Pills (20px+) are for badges and pills only. Modals use 12px. Standard cards use 8-10px. Row-level items use 6-7px.

Radius	Rule / when to use	Reference project	New project
50% (circle)	Spinners, progress dots, avatar indicators. Never on content containers.	Spinner ring, stage dots, skill number badge	
20px (pill)	Level badges, tab pills, link pills. Full pill shape. Never on cards.	Level tag, tab pill, feedback link	
16px	Featured or hero card. One per screen maximum. Reserved for highest visual hierarchy.	PreviewSection outer wrapper only	

12px	Modals and overlays. Full-screen interruptions.	SkillExpertOverlay modal, CompareWarningModal	
10px	Standard info card. Default for bordered container that is not a row item.	IntroCard, CommunityNote, explanation cards	
8px	Picker items, notices, error boxes. Slightly softer than standard card.	OccCard, DeviceNote, ErrBox	
7px	Row-level items. Skill rows, search inputs. Interactive items a user taps.	SkillRow, search input, picker re-search	
6px	Sub-cards and micro-containers inside a card.	AI Tool / Approach micro-cards	
5px	Code blocks and pre elements.	Prompt pre block	
4px (flat label)	Status badges that are labels, not pills. Never rounded further.	Copy and go, Quick prep, Prep needed	

4.2 Spacing Scale

Role	Rule	Reference value	New project value
Page outer padding (mobile)	<code>--content-pad</code> CSS variable. 12px minimum on mobile.	12px	
Page outer padding (tablet+)	<code>--content-pad</code> at 600px+. Must not crowd content at small tablet.	20px	
Page outer padding (laptop+)	<code>--content-pad</code> at 900px+. Generous breathing room.	32px	

Card internal padding	Standard card padding. Consistent across all card types.	14px 16px	
Row internal padding	Tighter padding for row-level interactive items.	9px 13px header / 11px 14px body	
Grid gap (standard)	Between card columns in grids.	10px	
Flex gap (badge row)	Between inline badge / pill elements.	6-8px	
[RULE] Never zero gap	Adjacent interactive elements must have a minimum 4px gap. Tap targets that touch produce errors on touch screens.	-	-

4.3 Box Shadow

Role	Rule	Reference value	New project value
Hero / featured card	Use only on the highest visual hierarchy card per screen.	0 4px 24px rgba(0,0,0,0.09), 0 1px 4px rgba(0,0,0,0.06)	
Modal / overlay panel	Stronger shadow to lift modal above backdrop.	0 8px 32px rgba(0,0,0,0.22)	
[RULE] No shadow on standard cards	Standard bordered cards use border only. Shadow and border together create visual noise. Choose one.	border only - no shadow	

5. Device and Responsive Configuration

5.1 Viewport and HTML Configuration

Setting	Rule	Reference project	New project
viewport meta	Always include <code>interactive-widget=resizes-content</code> so the on-screen keyboard resizes viewport instead of overlapping content.	<code>width=device-width, initial-scale=1.0, interactive-widget=resizes-content</code>	
App height unit	Use <code>100svh</code> (small viewport height). Handles keyboard resize natively on iOS and Android.	<code>100svh</code> with <code>100vh</code> fallback	
<code>html lang</code>	Always set. Must match copy language throughout.	<code>en-GB</code>	
<code>html zoom</code>	Optional: global scale at large desktop breakpoint. Use only when UI was designed at mobile scale and benefits from proportional enlargement.	<code>zoom: 1.1 at min-width: 1153px</code>	

5.2 Breakpoint System

Rule: Define breakpoints by content need, not device category. The values below are derived from when content requires more space, not from device specs. Adapt them if your content has different inflection points.

Breakpoint name	CSS px	Reference changes	New project changes
Mobile default	0-599px	<code>--content-pad</code> 12px. Single column. All panels stacked.	
Mobile+	600px	<code>--content-pad</code> 20px. <code>main-content</code> padding adjusts. <code>t-*</code> classes scale up.	
Tablet portrait	768px	<code>body</code> 15px. <code>t-heading</code> 18px. <code>site-title</code> 16px.	

Tablet landscape	900px	--content-pad 32px. --content-max 900px.	
Desktop zoom trigger	1153px	html { zoom: 1.1 } activates in index.html .	
Desktop	1024px+	body 16px. t-heading 20px. result-text-sm 13px.	
Large desktop	1200px+	--content-max 1000px. tab-label 13px.	
Wide desktop	1600px+	--content-max 1080px.	
2K	2000px+	body 18px. html 18px. t-heading 24px. --content-max 1200px.	
4K	2560px+	body 20px. html 20px. t-heading 28px. --content-max 1320px.	

5.3 Content Width Constraints

CSS variable	Breakpoint	Reference value	New project value
--content-max (default)	0-899px	820px	
--content-max	900px+	900px	
--content-max	1200px+	1000px	
--content-max	1600px+	1080px	
--content-max	2000px+	1200px	
--content-max	2560px+	1320px	
--content-pad	0-599px	12px	
--content-pad	600-899px	20px	
--content-pad	900px+	32px	

5.4 Responsive Patterns

Pattern	Rule	Reference usage	New project usage
<code>flex-wrap: wrap</code>	Use on any row of badges, buttons, or pills. Wraps gracefully with no breakpoint needed.	Badge rows, action button rows	
<code>auto-fit / auto-fill</code> grid	Use for card grids that should self-determine column count. <code>minmax(min(Xpx, 100%), 1fr) .</code>	PersonaToggle <code>minmax(200px, 1fr)</code>	
ResizeObserver (<code>isNarrow</code>)	For layout-driven narrow detection inside a component, use ResizeObserver not a media query. Threshold: component width < Xpx.	ComparisonPanel < 560px	
<code>overflowX: auto</code>	Use on horizontally scrolling rows (tab bars, chip rows). Never clip content on narrow screens.	Tab bar, career path pills, comparison chips	
<code>whiteSpace: nowrap + flexShrink: 0</code>	Always apply to badges and pills. Prevents mid-label wrapping.	All level badge tags	
[RULE] No hover-only interactive states	Any element that carries meaning must be always-visible. Hover states enhance - they do not reveal. Touch screens have no hover.	-	-

6. Component Patterns

Rule: Every project uses these six patterns. Apply your token values from Sections 3 and 4 to the formula. Do not invent new patterns without documenting them here first.

6.1 Primary Card

Property	Rule	Reference value	New project value
background	Always surface token. Never bg token.	#ffffff	
border	1px solid border token.	1px solid #dde3ec	
borderRadius	10px for standard. 16px for hero card (one per screen max).	10px	
padding	14px 16px standard. Consistent across all cards.	14px 16px	
boxShadow	None on standard cards. Border only. Shadow reserved for hero card and modals.	none	
Hover state	If card is clickable, add hover: border-color accent, background accentSoft.	borderColor #c3d3f5, bg #e8f0fe	

6.2 Expandable Row

Property	Rule	Reference value	New project value
border (closed)	2px solid border token. Heavier than card - signals interactivity.	2px solid #dde3ec	
border (open)	2px solid relevant level / state border colour.	2px solid level.border	
background (open)	Level or state background colour. Signals expanded state visually.	level.bg	
borderRadius	7px. Slightly tighter than card.	7px	
Collapse	Always-visible triangle: ▲ open, ▼ closed.	▲ / ▼ at 10px	

indicator	Never hide behind hover.	mutedLight	
Body indent	Left-indent body content past the row number or icon. Creates visual hierarchy.	padding-left: 41px	

6.3 Status Badge / Pill

Property	Rule	Reference value (pill)	New project value
<code>borderRadius</code> (pill)	20px for pills used as navigation or level indicators.	20px	
<code>borderRadius</code> (label)	4px for flat status labels (readiness badges). Signals status, not action.	4px	
<code>fontSize</code>	9-11px. Never larger than surrounding body text.	9-10px	
<code>fontWeight</code>	600-700. Bold enough to read at small size.	600-700	
<code>padding</code>	Pill: 2px 9px . Label: 1px 6px .	2px 9px / 1px 6px	
[RULE]	Always set <code>whiteSpace: nowrap</code> and <code>flexShrink: 0</code> on badges. Never let a badge wrap mid-label.	-	-

6.4 Status Banner (Info / Warning / Error / Success)

Type	Ref background	Ref border	Heading + body text colour	New project
Info (blue)	#eff6ff	#bfbdbf	Heading #1e40af . Body #1e3a8a .	
Warning (amber)	#fffbeb	#fcd9a0	Heading #b45309 . Body #92400e .	

Error (red)	#fdecea	#f5c6c2	Heading #c0392b . Body #78350f .	
Success (green)	#f0fdf4	#a7f3d0	Heading #166534 . Body #166534 .	

6.5 Navigation Tabs

Property	Rule	Reference value	New project value
Active indicator	3px bottom border in accent colour. Not a background fill. Underline signals active, not selection.	3px solid #1a56db	
Active text	Accent colour. <code>fontWeight: 700</code> .	#1a56db, 700	
Inactive text	Muted token. <code>fontWeight: 700</code> still - tabs are always bold.	#6b7a8d, 700	
Container	2px solid accent top border on the nav section. Visual landmark separating nav from content.	2px solid #1a56db top border	
Overflow	<code>overflowX: auto</code> on the tab bar container. Never clip tabs on narrow screens.	<code>overflowX:</code> auto	

6.6 Code / Prompt Block

Property	Rule	Reference value	New project value
Outer container background	Light blue tint distinguishes from white card surface.	#f0f9ff	
Outer container	Same blue family, slightly darker.	1px solid	

border		#bae6fd	
Pre / code block background	Deeper tint than outer container.	#e0f2fe	
Pre / code text colour	Dark blue, not black. Preserves the blue family throughout.	#0c4a6e	
fontFamily	monospace always. Never system-ui.	monospace	
borderRadius	Outer 7px. Pre block 5px.	7px / 5px	

7. Copy and Tone Rules

Rule: These apply to every string of copy in the product - labels, error messages, loading states, empty states, button text, and help text. Not just marketing copy.

#	Rule	Apply like this	Not like this
1	UK English throughout	analyse, organise, colour, behaviour, programme	analyze, organize, color, behavior, program
2	No em dashes or en dashes	Use hyphens instead: side-by-side, step-by-step	side-by-side with em or en dash characters
3	Third-person neutral	The tool shows every skill in this role.	We show you every skill in your role.
4	Never prescribe	One approach worth considering... / It may be worth...	You should... / You must... / The best choice is...
5	Indicative framing	A starting point, not a final assessment. Results may vary.	Definitive results. Accurate assessment.
6	No emojis (default)	Use Unicode icons (arrows, bullets, geometric shapes)	Emoji unless explicitly approved per context

7	No brochure language	Each role has a prompt card with a ready-to-use AI prompt.	Empowering you with cutting-edge AI insights.
8	Warm error messages	Something unexpected happened. Please try again.	Error 500. Request failed.
9	Word economy	Use: to / several / ensure / due to / if / regarding	in order to / a number of / it is important to / as a result of / in the event that / with regard to
10	Labels as invitations	Fresh Graduate. Industry Crossover.	You as a fresh graduate. If you are a crossover...

8. Before You Ship - Checklist

Run this checklist before every production deployment. Every unchecked item is a known issue that must be documented if not fixed.

Typography and Colour

- All body copy is 12px minimum on mobile.
- All badges and micro-labels are 9px minimum.
- No raw hex values in component code - all colours use token names.
- Every colour has a semantic role documented in the design system.
- `text-*` CSS classes are applied to all text that should scale at breakpoints.
- Colour contrast is legible at all sizes (visually verified on device).

Layout and Responsive

- All layouts verified at 375px width (mobile default).
- All layouts verified at 768px, 1024px, and 1440px.
- No content is clipped or hidden on any tested viewport.
- Tab bars and pill rows use `overflowX: auto` and do not clip on narrow screens.
- All interactive elements have a minimum 36px touch target height.

- Keyboard (on-screen) does not obscure the active input field on iOS and Android.

Interactive States

- Every interactive card has a hover state (`onMouseEnter` / `onMouseLeave`).
- If one card of a type has a hover state, all cards of that type have a hover state.
- No feature or content is accessible via hover only.
- All collapsible panels show ▲ / ▼ indicators in always-visible position.
- Buttons are always visible - never in the same flex row as wrapping badge elements.

Copy and Tone

- No em dashes or en dashes anywhere in the UI copy.
- No second-person prescriptive language (you should, you must).
- Error messages are warm and specific, not generic HTTP language.
- Loading states show meaningful progress, not just a spinner.
- Empty states explain what to do, not just that there is nothing here.
- All UK English spellings verified (analyse not analyze, colour not color).

Content Integrity

- No two panels on the same screen repeat the same content in different words.
- Every colour on screen encodes a meaning the user can learn.
- AI-generated content is framed as indicative, not definitive.
- Sources are attributed where visible (ESCO CC BY 4.0 or equivalent).
- Help tips are placed adjacent to the element they explain, not at the bottom of the page.

Performance and Technical

- External font CDN dependency is documented and scoped to the minimum required component.
- No API calls are fired on page load without user intent (search, selection, or navigation).
- Loading states have a visible timeout or error path - no infinite spinners.
- Vite build passes with zero warnings before deployment.

- Deploy via `vercel --prod` after `npm install` . Never auto-deploy from GitHub without review.

Brand & UI Standards - Builder Playbook v1.0 Reference project: AI Readiness across Skills and Competences (takearoundabout.com, v2.0.7) Adrian K. L. Ang | 8 Apr 2026 | linkedin.com/in/angadrian Sometimes the scenic route is the right one.